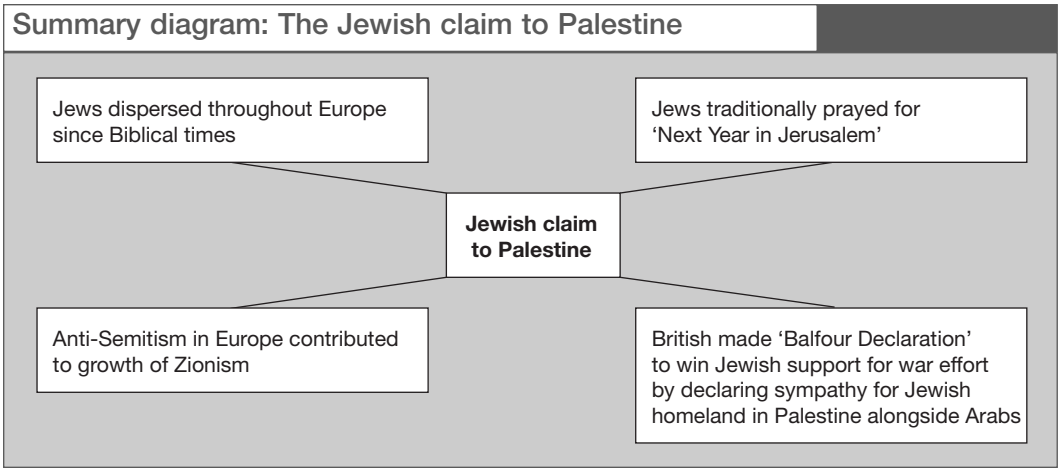


2 | The Arab Claim to Palestine

Key question
What was the Arab claim to Palestine?

Originally, the Arabs lived in the desert area which is today mostly Saudi Arabia (see map on page 9). They all spoke the same language, Arabic. In the seventh century AD, most of the Arabs were converted to the religion of Islam. They became followers of **Muhammad** and became known as Muslims. From their homeland in Arabia, they swept across the Middle East and north Africa in the seventh and eighth centuries, spreading their new religion and their language. Palestine was one of the countries they took over. Today, the Arabs form the majority of the population in the Middle East and all speak the same language, Arabic.

In the Middle Ages, the Muslim Arabs produced one of the world's richest and most powerful civilisations. They made important discoveries in mathematics and medicine while their mosques are still some of the most beautiful buildings in the world. Their merchants bought and sold goods in Europe, Africa and Asia, and their lands grew rich. Then, in the sixteenth century, the **Ottoman** Turks (who were also Muslims but not Arabs) conquered much of the Middle East. The Arabs were forced to pay taxes and provide soldiers for their Turkish masters. In the late nineteenth century the Arabs tried several times to remove their Turkish rulers. Their aim was to re-establish Arab rule in the Middle East, including Palestine. In 1913, the first Arab National Congress was held and, a year later, the Arab Nationalist Manifesto was published. This called for independence from Turkey and unity among the Arabs:

> Arise, O ye Arabs! Take out the sword from the scabbard. Do not let an oppressive tyrant [Turkey], who only despises you, remain in your country; cleanse your country from those who show their hatred to you, to your race and to your language.
>
> O ye Arabs! You all dwell in one land, you speak one language, so be also one nation and one land.
>
> Do not become divided amongst yourselves.

Key terms

Muhammad
Born in the Arabian city of Mecca in AD 572. For Muslims, he is the messenger and prophet of God.

Ottoman
The name of the Turkish dynasty, named after its founder, Osman. In the sixteenth century, the Turkish empire conquered much of south-east Europe and the Middle East.